

University of Zagreb
Faculty of Croatian Studies

Philosophy of Politics:
Marxism and communism in theory and
practice

Sandro Scansi

Marxism and Communism in Theory and Practice

- From Marxist theory to revolutionary politics
- Revolution, class and the state
- Soviet communism as a historical project
- Planning, bureaucracy and technology
- Central question: *What happens when a theory of social transformation becomes a system of government?*

From Marx to Marxism

- Marx left a critique of capitalism rather than a detailed model of communist government
- After Marx, his ideas were systematized into competing Marxist traditions
- Major disputes concerned revolution, democracy, the state and economic organization
- Marxism therefore developed beyond Marx

The Communist Horizon

- Abolition of capitalist class relations
- Social control of the means of production
- Overcoming exploitation and alienation
- Eventual emergence of a classless society
- Communism is conceived as a transformation of social relations, not merely redistribution

Two Phases of Communist Society

- Marx distinguishes an initial and a higher phase of post-capitalist society
- The initial phase still bears characteristics inherited from capitalism
- The higher phase presupposes much greater productive abundance
- Distribution could ultimately follow the principle: *“From each according to his ability, to each according to his needs.”*

The Problem of Transition

- Capitalism cannot simply disappear overnight
- Marx envisages a period of revolutionary transformation
- Political power remains necessary during this transition
- Marx calls its political form the “*revolutionary dictatorship of the proletariat*”
- But he provides relatively limited institutional detail about this transitional order

What Does “Dictatorship of the Proletariat” Mean?

- The nineteenth-century phrase refers to the political rule of a class
- Marx contrasts proletarian political power with bourgeois class rule
- It does not by itself provide a detailed constitutional design
- Later Marxists profoundly disagreed about its institutional meaning
- This ambiguity becomes historically important

The State and Communism

- Marx treats the state as historically connected to class society
- Communist transformation should alter the social basis of political power
- The transitional state therefore presents a theoretical paradox
- *How can political power be used to create conditions in which class-based political power becomes unnecessary?*

Revolution or Reform?

- Late nineteenth-century Marxism divides over political strategy
- Can socialism emerge through parliamentary democracy?
- Or does capitalism require revolutionary rupture?
- Reformist and revolutionary Marxists provide different answers
- This dispute becomes one of the central divisions of the socialist movement

The Russian Problem

- Marx analyzed capitalism primarily with Western Europe in mind
- Imperial Russia remained predominantly agrarian
- Industrialization was uneven but created concentrated urban working populations
- Political institutions remained highly authoritarian
- Russian Marxists therefore confronted conditions different from those Marx had expected

Lenin's Intervention

- Vladimir Lenin adapts Marxism to Russian revolutionary conditions
- Revolutionary consciousness requires political organization
- A disciplined revolutionary party becomes central
- Revolution cannot simply wait for capitalism to mature
- Marxism becomes a theory of political organization as well as historical development

The Vanguard Party

- Workers' economic struggles do not automatically produce revolutionary politics
- A revolutionary organization must develop political consciousness and strategy
- Professional revolutionaries provide organization and continuity
- The party becomes the instrument through which revolutionary transformation is coordinated

The Party and the Class

- Marx emphasizes the proletariat as an historical agent
- Lenin gives the revolutionary party a decisive organizational role
- This creates a fundamental theoretical problem:
- *Does the party represent the working class or substitute itself for the working class?*
- The relationship between class and party becomes central to twentieth-century communism

The Russian Revolution

- February 1917 ends the Romanov monarchy
- Political authority becomes divided and unstable
- Bolsheviks gain influence among workers and soldiers
- October 1917 brings the Bolsheviks to power
- Revolutionary Marxism now confronts the practical problem of governing

Revolution Becomes Administration

- Taking political power is different from governing society
- Food must be distributed
- Production must continue
- Armies must be organized
- Infrastructure must function
- Revolutionary politics therefore becomes a problem of administration and coordination

Civil War and War Communism

- Civil war follows the Bolshevik Revolution
- The new regime faces military and economic crisis
- Economic administration becomes highly centralized
- Grain requisitioning and state control expand
- Emergency conditions profoundly shape the emerging Soviet political order

The New Economic Policy

- Lenin introduces the New Economic Policy in 1921
- Limited market mechanisms are restored
- Small-scale private economic activity is permitted
- The state retains control over major sectors
- Socialist construction therefore temporarily incorporates market mechanisms

A Fundamental Communist Problem

- Markets coordinate through decentralized exchange
- Communist theory seeks social control over production
- But complex economies require enormous amounts of information
- *How can millions of production and consumption decisions be coordinated without capitalist markets?*
- This becomes a central practical problem of communist economic organization

Stalin and the Transformation of the Soviet System

- Stalin consolidates political power after Lenin's death
- Rapid industrialization becomes a central objective
- Agriculture is forcibly collectivized
- Central planning expands dramatically
- Political repression intensifies

Collectivization

- Agriculture is reorganized around collective and state farms
- The policy aims to transform rural property relations and increase state control over agricultural production
- Resistance accompanies implementation
- Collectivization involves extensive coercion and severe social disruption
- Agricultural transformation becomes inseparable from state-building

Industrialization

- Soviet leadership prioritizes rapid heavy industrial development
- Five-Year Plans establish production targets
- Resources are directed toward strategically selected sectors
- Industrial capacity expands substantially
- The human and material costs of rapid transformation are also substantial

The Command Economy

- Major productive assets are state-controlled
- Central institutions formulate production targets
- Investment decisions are politically determined
- Prices play a reduced coordinating role compared with market economies
- Economic coordination increasingly depends on administrative information

The Knowledge Problem

- Planners need information about:
 - resources
 - productive capacity
 - labor
 - transportation
 - demand
- The larger the economy becomes, the more complex coordination becomes
- Economic planning therefore becomes an ****information problem****

Political Centralization

- Soviet political institutions become increasingly centralized
- The Communist Party occupies the dominant political position
- Political opposition is sharply restricted
- Party and state institutions become deeply interconnected
- The revolutionary party becomes a permanent governing organization

Stalinism and Political Repression

- Stalin's rule includes extensive political repression
- Purges target party members, officials, military officers and wider populations
- Forced-labor institutions expand
- Political accusations become instruments of institutional conflict
- Soviet political practice therefore diverges substantially from an image of emancipated collective self-government

Theory and Practice

- Marx anticipated the overcoming of class domination
- Soviet practice produced powerful centralized institutions
- Marx associated communism with human emancipation
- Soviet political structures substantially restricted political pluralism
- Central question: *How should we explain the divergence between theoretical aspirations and institutional outcomes?*

Possible Explanations of the Divergence

- Conditions of revolution and civil war
- Russia's economic and institutional inheritance
- Leninist party organization
- Problems of centralized economic coordination
- Political struggles and leadership choices
- These explanations need not be mutually exclusive

Ideology and Political Language

- Communist political language provided categories for interpreting society
- “Class,” “bourgeois,” “proletarian” and “reactionary” acquired political functions
- Language could establish boundaries between legitimate and illegitimate positions
- Ideological vocabulary became embedded in institutions
- Gerovitch analyzes this phenomenon through Soviet scientific discourse

Gerovitch: “Speaking Bolshevik”

- Soviet scientists operated within an ideologically structured political language
- Scientific claims could be evaluated partly through political categories
- Researchers learned to formulate arguments using acceptable ideological vocabulary
- Language therefore became connected to institutional survival and authority
- Gerovitch describes this late-Stalinist discourse as *Newspeak*

Science and Ideology

- Scientific knowledge does not exist institutionally outside politics
- Soviet scientific debates could involve ideological classifications
- Categories such as “formalism” or “idealism” acquired political significance
- The boundary between scientific and ideological judgment could shift
- *Who determines what counts as legitimate knowledge?*

Cybernetics

- Cybernetics studies communication, information and control
- Initially attacked in the Soviet Union as ideologically suspect
- Its political position changes during the post-Stalin period
- It becomes associated with scientific modernization
- Technology appears capable of improving socialist administration

From Newspeak to Cyberspeak

- Khrushchev's "Thaw" creates greater intellectual space
- Cybernetics is rehabilitated
- Mathematical language appears more objective than ideological rhetoric
- Scientists present cybernetics as a universal language of problem-solving
- Gerovitch calls this emerging discourse *Cyberspeak*

“Cybernetics in the Service of Communism”

- Cybernetics becomes associated with reform of Soviet science and administration
- Computers promise faster information processing
- Mathematical models promise greater rationality
- Technology appears capable of improving economic planning
- Communism increasingly intersects with a vision of *scientific governance*

The Dream of Rational Planning

- Imagine an economy as an information system
- Production generates data
- Consumption generates demand signals
- Computers process information
- Planners adjust production
- Could technology solve the coordination problem of a planned economy?

Politics Cannot Simply Become Engineering

- Economic decisions involve competing priorities
- Information does not determine values
- Institutions decide which goals matter
- Technical optimization cannot eliminate political disagreement
- *Who chooses the objectives that the computer is asked to optimize?*

Cybernetics and Political Reform

- Soviet cyberneticists sometimes presented technical language as objective and politically neutral
- This language could challenge older ideological forms of scientific authority
- Yet cybernetics itself became incorporated into official ideological discourse
- Gerovitch describes the eventual synthesis as “*CyberNewspeak*”
- Reformist scientific language could itself become institutionalized

The Limits of Central Planning

- Central institutions confront enormous informational demands
- Enterprises can have incentives to manipulate information
- Quantitative targets can distort production priorities
- Innovation can conflict with bureaucratic routines
- The problem is not simply calculation but *information, incentives and institutions*

Marxism and Soviet Communism

- Marxism provides categories of class, exploitation and historical transformation
- Leninism adds a distinctive theory of revolutionary organization
- Soviet institutions develop under revolution, civil war, economic transformation and political struggle
- Soviet communism therefore cannot simply be treated as identical to every claim found in Marx
- But neither can historical practice be separated completely from ideological and institutional choices

The Central Theoretical Tensions

- Emancipation vs. political coercion
- Worker self-government vs. party leadership
- Social ownership vs. bureaucratic control
- Planning vs. decentralized information
- Scientific rationality vs. political judgment

Theory and Practice: Questions for Discussion

- Does revolutionary transformation require concentrated political power?
- Can concentrated power later dismantle itself?
- Can economic planning function without political centralization?
- Can technology solve problems that are fundamentally political?
- When does ideological commitment become an obstacle to institutional learning?

The Communist Question

- Marx: *Can class domination be overcome by transforming property and production?*
- Lenin: *What political organization can carry out revolutionary transformation?*
- Soviet experience: *How can a post-capitalist economy actually be governed?*
- Gerovitch: *Can information and technology make social organization rational?*
- Fundamental question: *Can a society consciously organize itself toward collective ends without creating new forms of domination?*